

« Expect India to win over 20 medals at the World Para Athletics Championships »

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India will mark a major milestone in para sport when it hosts the World Para Athletics Championships for the first time in New Delhi from September 27. PCI president Devendra Jhajharia expects the home contingent to win more than 20 medals and says the event will cement India's status as a capable host of global events.

How important is it for you that the World Championships are taking place in India?

Twenty years ago, I won gold with a world record at the 2004 Paralympics. When I returned, I told the Sports Minister I had funded my preparation because the government hadn't given me a single rupee. All I wanted was for Indian athletes not to go abroad to train and compete. As a player, it was my dream to compete in a big tournament at home. I couldn't, but as PCI president, I'm proud we've brought one here. For someone who struggled yet won three Paralympic

medals and the country's top awards, the Arjuna Award, Major Dhyani Chand Khel Ratna, Padma Shri and Padma Bhushan, it's heartening that others won't face the same challenges.

What do you hope this tournament will achieve?

I'll be happy to see the size of the delegations — more than 1,500 athletes from 107 countries. The world will see not just our performances but also our systems. It's historic both because we're hosting it and because of the results we expect. We won 17 medals at the last World Championships in Kobe; this time, I expect over 20. I also hope visiting teams go back with good things to say about India.

How did India secure the opportunity to host the World Championships?

It took about a year and a half for us to get this chance. There is a long process before the right to host a world championship is given. The

first step is simply having the will to host such an event. This happened because the government told me we had to organise a major event.

We had a meeting during the Paris Paralympics where the sports secretary and I were present, and we said we would bid for a World Championship. It was the first time India had even requested the chance to host an event of this scale. It helped a lot that India won 29 medals at the Paris Paralympics, 17 of them in athletics. The International Paralympic Committee and World Para Athletics saw how much we had grown in athletics. I think that's also why they chose us.

What were the challenges of hosting a tournament like this for the first time?

I wouldn't say it was difficult. Having competed in several World Championships, I knew what is needed — smooth travel, proper hotels, training and competition venues. It was just about implementing that.